

Medical English — Grammar Cheat Sheet

Tiempos verbales, modales, condicionales, voz pasiva, subordinación y artículos · Inglés Médico I · Semana 3

The 12 verb tenses — signal words · use · form · example

TENSE	SIGNAL WORDS	USE	FORM	AFFIRMATIVE · NEGATIVE · QUESTION
Simple Present	every day, always, usually, often, never, sometimes	Habits, repeated actions, general truths.	verb (he/she/it + -s/-es)	She studies. · She doesn't study. · Does she study?
Present Continuous	now, at the moment	Happening at the time of speaking; arranged future.	am/is/are + verb-ing	I am working. · I'm not working. · Am I working?
Present Perfect	just, yet, ever, never, already, since, for, how long	Past action with a present consequence.	have/has + past participle	I have worked. · I haven't worked. · Have you worked?
Present Perfect Continuous	all day, the whole day, since, for, how long	Action that began in the past and continues to now.	have/has + been + verb-ing	I have been working. · ... haven't been ... · Have you been working?
Simple Past	yesterday, last ..., ... ago, in 1990	Finished action in the past, no link to the present.	verb-ed / 2nd column (irregular)	I worked / I went. · I didn't work. · Did I work?
Past Continuous	while	Action in progress when another action happened.	was/were + verb-ing	I was working. · I wasn't working. · Was I working?
Past Perfect	already, just, never, before	Action completed before another past action.	had + past participle	I had worked. · I hadn't worked. · Had I worked?
Past Perfect Continuous	how long, since, for	Ongoing past action that ended at a defined past point.	had + been + verb-ing	I had been working. · ... hadn't been ... · Had you been working?
Simple Future	tomorrow, next week/ month/year	Predictions; spontaneous decisions.	will + verb	I will work. · I won't work. · Will I work?
Future Continuous	at this time tomorrow	Action in progress at a certain future time.	will be + verb-ing	I will be working. · I won't be working. · Will I be working?
Future Perfect	by next week, by then	Action that will be finished before a future point.	will have + past participle	I will have worked. · I won't have worked. · Will I have worked?
Future Perfect Continuous	by ... for + duration	Ongoing action up to a point in the future.	will have been + verb-ing	I will have been working. · ... won't have been ... · Will you have been working?

Regla de oro: el **signal word** te dice el tiempo. *yesterday*→simple past · *now*→present continuous · *since/for*→present perfect · *while*→past continuous · *by next week*→future perfect.

Verb TO BE — present & simple past

PRESENT	EXAMPLE	SIMPLE PAST	EXAMPLE
I → am	I am a nurse.	I / he / she / it → was	I was at the hospital last night.
he / she / it → is	She is a doctor.	we / you / they → were	They were my patients.
we / you / they → are	They are patients.	Negative	wasn't / weren't (was not / were not).
Question / Negative	Is he a cardiologist? · No, he isn't .	Wh- question	Wh- + was/were + subject: What was his occupation?

Modal verbs — meaning & use

MODAL	MEANING / USE	EXAMPLE	MODAL	MEANING / USE	EXAMPLE
can	ability · permission	I can read complex terms. Can I go?	have to	external obligation	I have to study tonight.
can't	impossibility · denied permission	She can't be his mom, she's too young.	shall	offers / suggestions	Shall I help you?
could	possibility · past ability · polite permission	Could I see the doctor tomorrow?	should / ought to	advice / recommendation	You should see the x-rays first.
may	possibility · formal permission	It may rain. May I leave the table?	had better	strong advice / warning	You had better sleep more.
might	(weaker) possibility	It might rain tomorrow.	would	offers · hypothetical	Would you like a cup of water?
must	obligation · strong deduction	You must take your medicine.	will	future · willingness	The patient will recover.

Rules for all modals: they are auxiliaries and **do not accept conjugation** (no -s in 3rd person: **He can**, not "he cans") · **no do/does** in questions, **no don't/doesn't** in negatives · followed by an infinitive without "to" (She must **study**) · **no infinitive or -ing forms** ("to can" X, "musting" X).

Conditionals 0 · 1 · 2 · 3

TYPE	IF-CLAUSE	MAIN CLAUSE	USE · CERTAINTY	EXAMPLE
Zero	if + simple present	simple present	Permanent truths, scientific facts. 100% certainty.	If you heat water to 100°, it boils .
First	if + simple present	will / can / must + verb	Realistic present/future. 50% possibility.	If I specialize , I will be on cardiology.
Second	if + simple past	would / could + verb	Improbable/impossible now. 0–5%.	If I had more time, I would exercise more.
Third	if + past perfect	would have + participle	Impossible past; regrets. 0%.	If he had taken it, he would have recovered .

unless = "if not / only if" — never followed by *will* (Unless you hurry up, you **won't** catch the bus). · "If I **were** you, I'd ..." = second conditional used to give advice.

Passive voice

Form: Subject + be (auxiliary) + past participle + by + agent (optional)

Active: The doctor **diagnosed** appendicitis. → Passive: **Appendicitis was diagnosed by the doctor**.

The midwife delivered the twins → **The twins were delivered by the midwife**.

In the passive the **subject receives** the action. The agent (by ...) is optional.

Use the passive when:

- the **receiver** matters more than the doer
- the **agent is unknown** (My wallet has been stolen)
- the agent is **obvious or unimportant** (I am paid weekly)
- **formal / scientific** writing (Potassium was added and heated to 80°C)
- general statements (Passengers are reminded to fasten seatbelts)

Subordinate conjunctions & articles

Subordinating conjunctions link a dependent clause to an independent one:

after · before · since · although · than · that · unless · until · because · when · where · while · in order to · as long as · even though

Comma rule: subordinate clause **first** → comma after it (*Although it was close, we won.*).
Subordinate clause **after** the main clause → **no comma** (*We stayed until the show was over.*).

ARTICLE	USE	EXAMPLE
a	general; before a consonant sound	a vaccine, a doctor
an	general; before a vowel sound	an artery, an x-ray
the	specific / already known	The surgery was a success.
— (no article)	general plurals / uncountables	Health issues are genetic.

Common verbs — infinitive · simple past · past participle

INF.	PAST	PARTICIPLE	INF.	PAST	PARTICIPLE	INF.	PAST	PARTICIPLE
admit	admitted	admitted	be	was/were	been	know	knew	known
complain	complained	complained	become	became	become	lay	laid	laid
cure	cured	cured	begin	began	begun	lose	lost	lost
diagnose	diagnosed	diagnosed	break	broke	broken	make	made	made
examine	examined	examined	bleed	bled	bled	read	read	read
fracture	fractured	fractured	catch	caught	caught	run	ran	run
prescribe	prescribed	prescribed	feel	felt	felt	say	said	said
recover	recovered	recovered	go	went	gone	take	took	taken

Regular verbs: *simple past* = *past participle* = *infinitive* + -ed. Irregular verbs use the 2nd column for simple past and the 3rd for the participle.